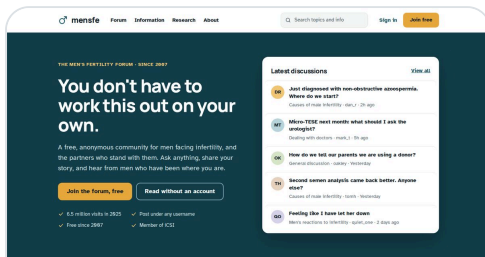


Four directions for the Mensfe forum

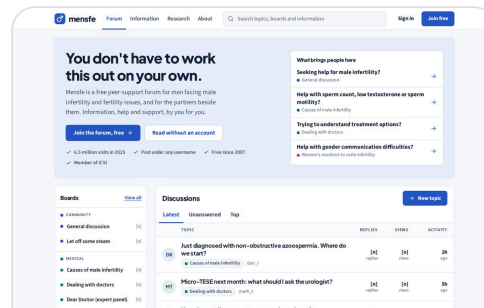
Each direction redesigns the same forum around the same content: a forum-first homepage, the board index, a topic page and a medical information page, all mobile-ready and built to fix the issues in the SEO audit.

Directions A–C present the forum through a modern website front; Direction D keeps the look and feel of a true message board. Please pick one direction (or the parts you like from each) and we will develop it into the full site and SMF theme.



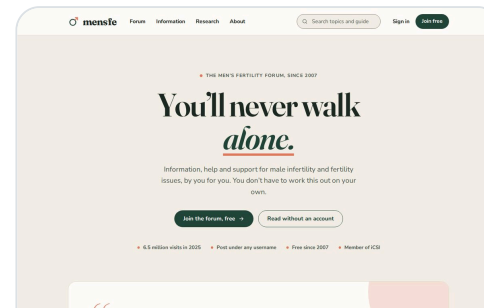
A • Harbour

Bold and branded. Confident, recognisable, a little dramatic.



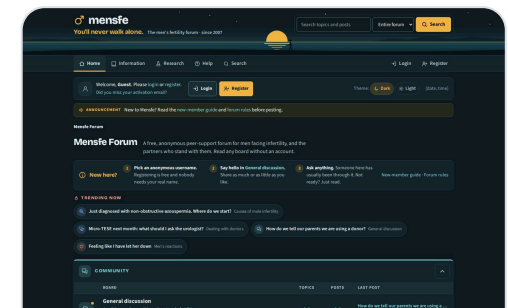
B • Clear

Clean and clinical. Feels like a modern health service crossed with a forum app.



C • Stories

Warm and human. Leads with members' voices, like a thoughtful magazine.

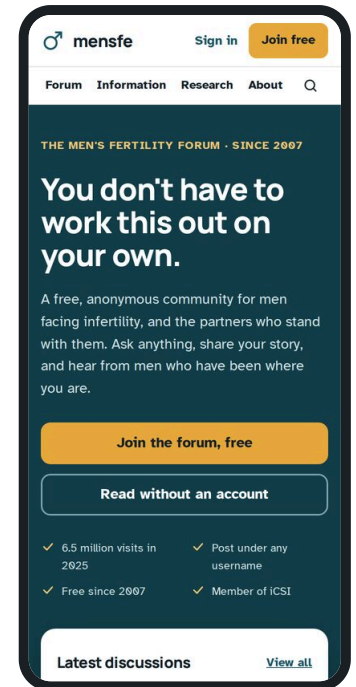
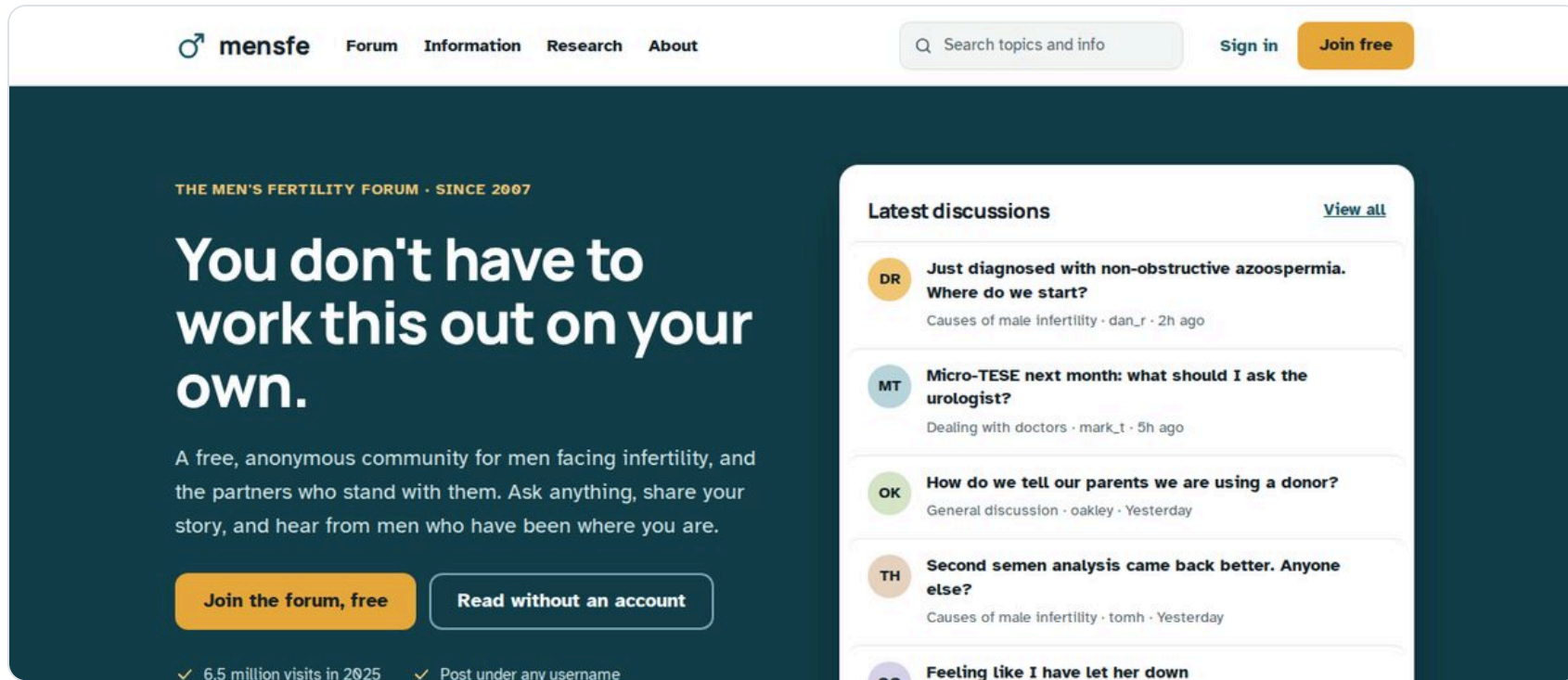


D • Forum

A true message board. Dark, distinctive and built around the board index.

All three share the same fixes: one clear heading per page, real text instead of text in images, latest discussions on the homepage, the founders' credentials on show, reviewer and date on medical pages, accessible contrast, and layouts that work on phones. Member counts appear as [n] placeholders, and sample posts are illustrative.

Harbour: bold and branded



Personality

- The deep sea-teal of the current shoreline banner, with a sunset-gold call to action
- A strong, memorable hero; the forum is visible from the first screen
- Best if Mensfe wants to look established and confident

Colour and type

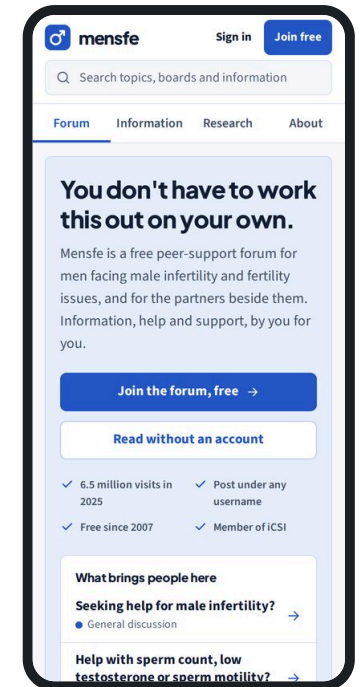
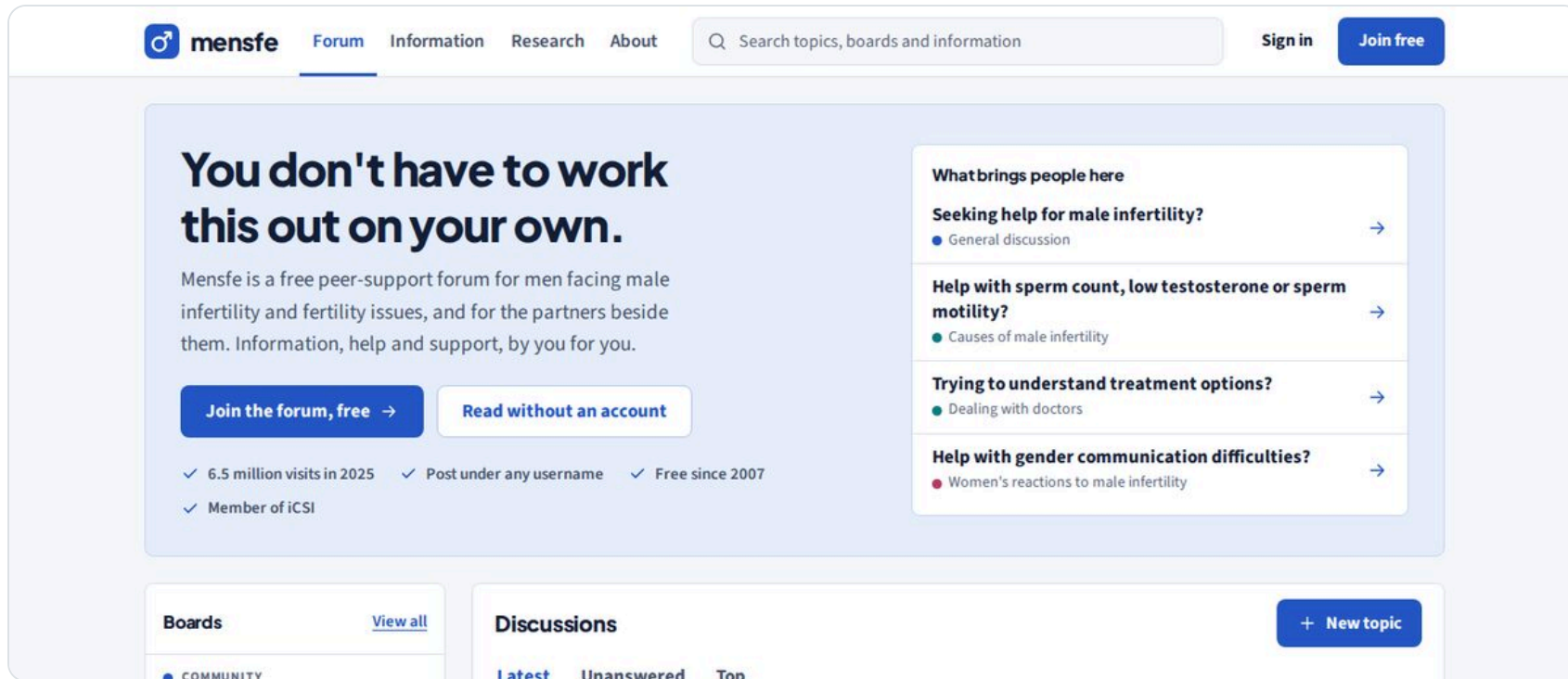


- Manrope headings, Atkinson Hyperlegible body text (designed for low-vision readability)

Watch-outs

- Dark bands are heavier on long pages
- Gold needs disciplined use to stay special

Clear: clean and clinical



Personality

- Calm, trustworthy and information-dense, like a modern health service
- A forum "app" layout: boards in a sidebar, a live topic feed with Latest, Unanswered and Top
- Best if Mensfe wants to feel medically credible and efficient

Colour and type

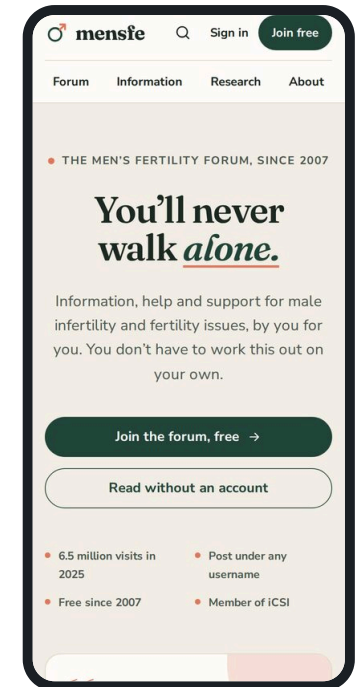
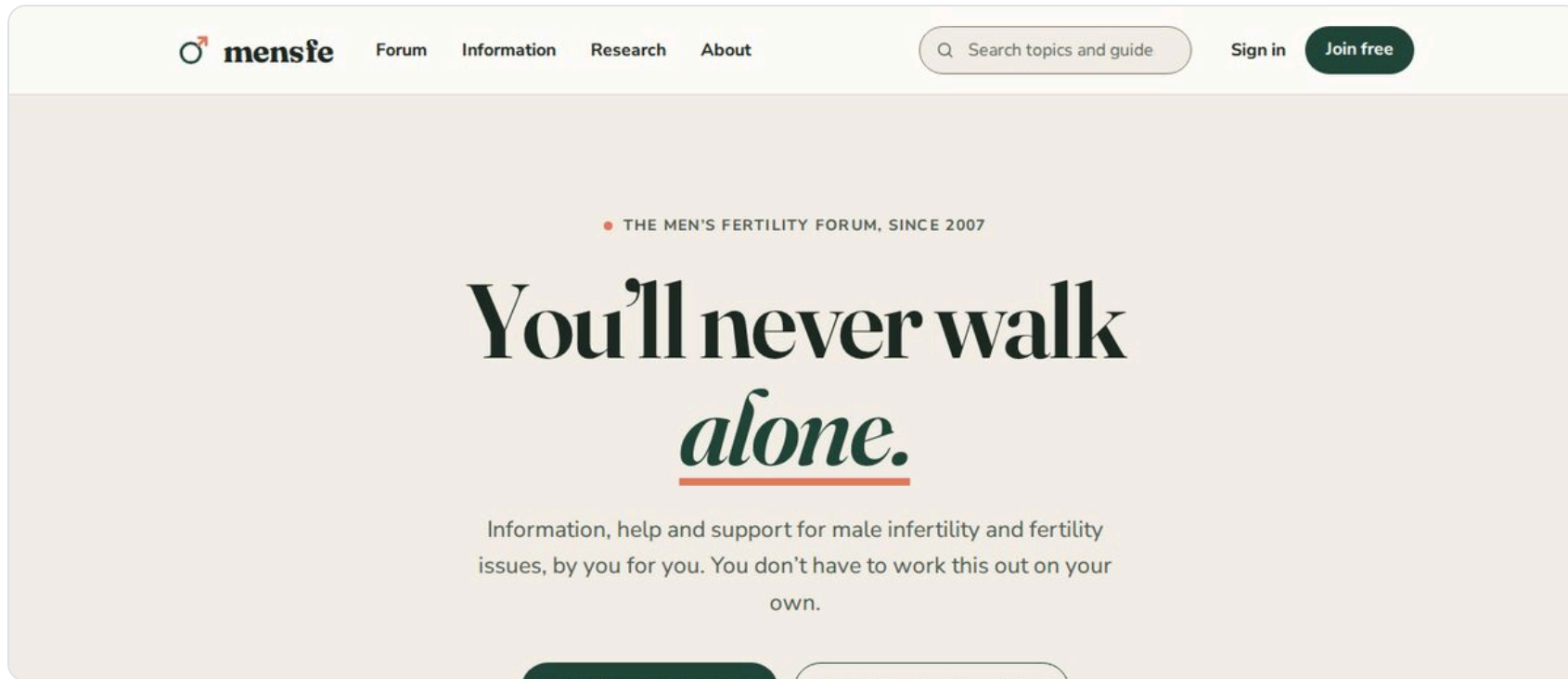


- Plus Jakarta Sans headings, Source Sans 3 body text

Watch-outs

- Can feel less personal; relies on activity in the feed
- Closest to SMF's own structure, so the easiest to theme

Stories: warm and human



Personality

- Editorial and reassuring; members' own words take centre stage
- Generous spacing and a serif voice for a reflective, magazine feel
- Best if Mensfe wants to emphasise empathy and the emotional side

Colour and type



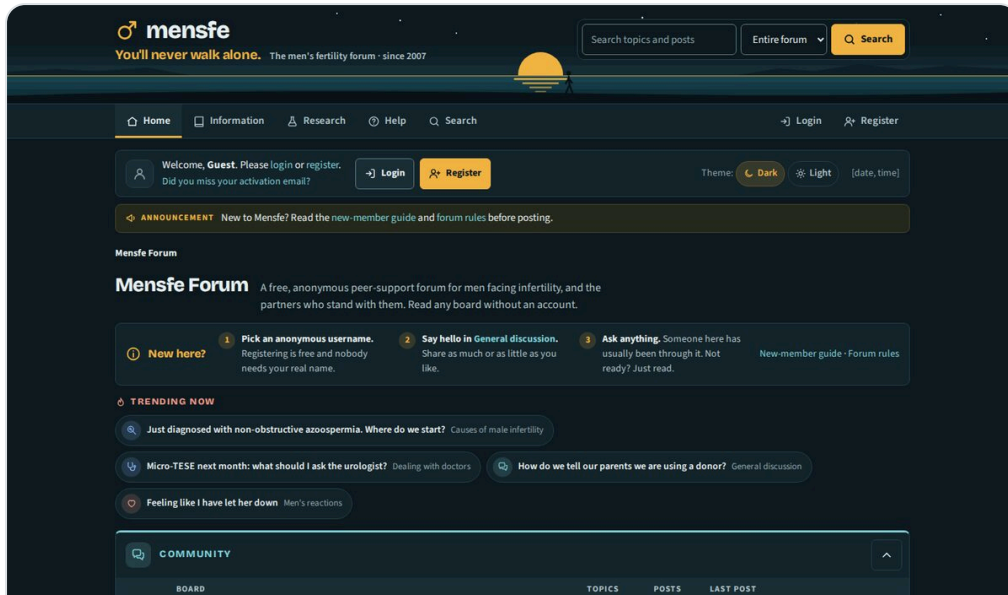
- Fraunces headings, Nunito Sans body text

Watch-outs

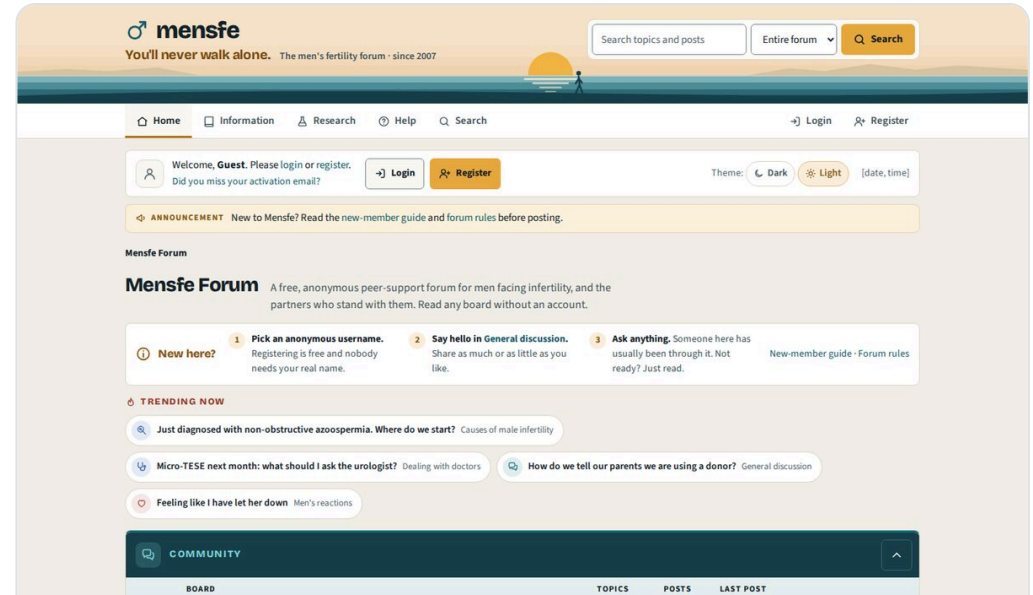
- Needs members' consent for featured stories
- Less dense, so more scrolling on busy boards

DIRECTION D

Forum: a true message board, reimagined



Dark · Midnight shoreline



Light · Daybreak shoreline

Personality

- The board index is the homepage, so regulars land straight in the forum
- Classic forum anatomy (category bars, last-post columns, profile panels beside posts, quick reply, info center) with a modern dark finish
- An illustrated night-shoreline banner revives "You'll never walk alone at Mensfe"

Colour and type



- Bricolage Grotesque headings, Source Sans 3 body text; each category has its own colour

Watch-outs

- Comes in dark and light; SMF can offer both as a member setting
- Closest to SMF's own templates, so it is the quickest to build

How the directions compare

	A · HARBOUR	B · CLEAR	C · STORIES	D · FORUM
First impression	Confident, branded	Professional, efficient	Warm, empathetic	Distinctive, community-first
Forum emphasis	Latest-discussions card in the hero; board grid	Live topic feed is the homepage	Featured member stories, then boards	The whole site is the forum; board index is home
Medical credibility	Good	Strongest	Good, more personal	Good (information section inside the forum)
Emotional warmth	Medium	Lower	Highest	Medium–high (members' voices up front)
Effort to theme SMF	Medium	Low	Medium–high	Lowest
Accessibility	Very high (hyperlegible body font)	High	High	High (contrast checked for dark mode)

What happens next: once a direction is chosen, we design the remaining pages (sign-up, profile, search, private messages and the 12 information guides), build the responsive SMF theme, and implement the SEO and AI visibility fixes from the audits during the same build.

THE MEN'S FERTILITY FORUM · SINCE 2007

You don't have to work this out on your own.

A free, anonymous community for men facing infertility, and the partners who stand with them. Ask anything, share your story, and hear from men who have been where you are.

[Join the forum, free](#)

[Read without an account](#)

- ✓

6.5 million visits in 2025
- ✓

Post under any username
- ✓

Free since 2007
- ✓

Member of iCSI

Latest discussions

[View all](#)

- DR

Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

Causes of male infertility · dan_r · 2h ago
- MT

Micro-TESE next month: what should I ask the urologist?

Dealing with doctors · mark_t · 5h ago
- OK

How do we tell our parents we are using a donor?

General discussion · oakley · Yesterday
- TH

Second semen analysis came back better. Anyone else?

Causes of male infertility · tomh · Yesterday
- GO

Feeling like I have let her down

Men's reactions to infertility · quiet_one · 2 days ago

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[General discussion](#)

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[Causes of male infertility](#)

Trying to understand treatment options?

[Dealing with doctors](#)

Finding it hard to talk about it as a couple?

[Women's reactions to male infertility](#)

Find your board

Every stage of the journey has a place. Read freely; join to post.

[All boards](#) →



COMMUNITY

General discussion

Anything and everything about male fertility.

[n] topics · [n] posts



COMMUNITY

Let off some steam

Somewhere to vent when it all gets too much.

[n] topics · [n] posts



MEDICAL

Causes of male infertility

Azoospermia, low count, varicocele, hormones and more.

[n] topics · [n] posts



MEDICAL

Dealing with doctors

Appointments, clinics, tests and treatment.

[n] topics · [n] posts



MEDICAL

Dear Doctor (expert panel)

Questions answered by our medical panel.

[n] topics · [n] posts



FEELINGS AND RELATIONSHIPS

Men's reactions to infertility

How it feels, from the men living it.

[n] topics · [n] posts



FEELINGS AND RELATIONSHIPS

Women's reactions to male infertility

Partners share their side.

[n] topics · [n] posts



RESEARCH

Current research on male infertility

New studies, trials and news.

[n] topics · [n] posts

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Share as much or as little as you want.
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[Infertility](#)

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[Varicocele](#)

[Treatment](#)

[Vasectomy reversal](#)

[Erection problems](#)

[Egg donation](#)

[Sperm donation](#)

[Nutrition](#)

[Counselling support](#)

Also: [Medical guide: jargon explained](#) [Emotive guide: the emotional side](#)

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[Browse the research board](#)

Latest: New study on sperm DNA fragmentation testing

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A JOURNEY
THROUGH MALE
INFERTILITY

STRONGER TOGETHER

PIP REILLY

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[View on Amazon](#) ↗

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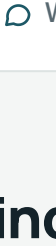
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[View all](#)

- 

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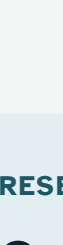
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[n] topics · [n] posts
- 

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[n] topics · [n] posts
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[n] topics · [n] posts
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[n] topics · [n] posts
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Partners share their side.
[n] topics · [n] posts
- 

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[View on Amazon](#)

[Home](#) > [Forum](#)

The Mensfe forum

Peer support for men facing infertility, and the partners who stand with them. Read any board without an account; join free to post under any username.

 Search topics, e.g. micro-TESE

Search

+ Start a new topic

[n] members · [n] topics · [n] posts

 Community

2 boards



General discussion
Anything and everything about male fertility.

[n] topics
[n] posts

OA

Last post

How do we tell our parents we are using a donor?

oakley · Yesterday



Let off some steam
Somewhere to vent when it all gets too much.

[n] topics
[n] posts

BI

Last post

Another pregnancy announcement at work today

big_al · 3h ago

 Medical

3 boards



Causes of male infertility
Azoospermia, low count, varicocele, hormones and more.

[n] topics
[n] posts

DA

Last post

Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

dan_r · 2h ago



Dealing with doctors
Appointments, clinics, tests and treatment.

[n] topics
[n] posts

MA

Last post

Micro-TESE next month: what should I ask the urologist?

mark_t · 5h ago



Dear Doctor (expert panel)
Questions answered by our medical panel.

[n] topics
[n] posts

BE

Last post

Is it worth repairing a varicocele before ICSI?

ben_w · 2 days ago

 Feelings and relationships

2 boards



Men's reactions to infertility
How it feels, from the men living it.

[n] topics
[n] posts

QU

Last post

Feeling Like I have let her down

quiet_one · 2 days ago



Women's reactions to male infertility
Partners share their side.

[n] topics
[n] posts

SA

Last post

How do I support him without making it worse?

sarah_m · 8h ago

 Research

1 board



Current research on male infertility
New studies, trials and news.

[n] topics
[n] posts

RE

Last post

New study on sperm DNA fragmentation testing

researchreader · Yesterday

Who's online

[n] members and [n] guests

Recently active: dan_r, mark_t, oakley, sarah_m and others posting under usernames.

Forum rules

1. **Be kind.** Everyone here is going through something hard.

2. **Protect your privacy.** Keep real names and clinics out of posts if you prefer.

3. **Share experience, not diagnoses.**
This is peer support, not medical advice.

4. **No selling or advertising.**

[Read the full rules](#) →

New-member guide

1 Pick an anonymous username.

2 Say hello in General discussion.

3 Ask anything. Someone has been there.

[Join free](#)

 **Peer support, not medical advice.** For questions about your own results, the Dear Doctor board and our [information guides](#) are a good place to start.

[Forum](#) > [Causes of male infertility](#) > [Topic](#)

Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

 Started by dan_r  2h ago  [n] replies  [n] following

 Reply

 Follow

 Share

Showing all [n] posts

Page 1 of 1

 DR

dan_r

Member

Original poster

Joined [date] · [n] posts · Posted 2h ago

My wife and I got the results last week. Two semen analyses, both showed no sperm at all, and the consultant thinks it is probably non-obstructive. My FSH came back high.

I honestly don't know what to feel. I keep reading about micro-TESE and success rates and it is all a blur. If anyone has been through this, what should we be asking at the next appointment?

 Helpful [n]

 Support [n]

 Quote

 Reply

 MT

mark_t

Member

Joined [date] · [n] posts · Posted 1h ago

I was exactly where you are three years ago. Write your questions down before the appointment, because you will forget them in the room. Ask whether they have checked your karyotype and for Y-chromosome microdeletions, because that changed what our options were.

And look after yourself. The first month was the hardest part for me.

 Helpful [n]

 Support [n]

 Quote

 Reply

 MF

Mensfe Team

Moderator

Joined [date] · [n] posts · Posted 48 min ago

Welcome, and thank you for posting. A lot of men read this board without ever writing, so this will help others too. Our [Azoospermia guide](#) explains the tests and treatment terms you will hear, and the [Counselling Support](#) page lists services if you would like to talk to someone.

 Helpful [n]

 Support [n]

 Quote

 Reply

 JO

jo_partner

Partner

Joined [date] · [n] posts · Posted 20 min ago

Wife of a member here. It is not your fault, and she is probably as worried about you as about the result. Talking to each other helped us more than anything the clinic said.

 Helpful [n]

 Support [n]

 Quote

 Reply

Reply to this topic

You're posting as your forum username. Share your experience; please don't diagnose.

Your reply

B

I





Write something supportive, or share what helped you.

☒ Notify me of replies

Post reply

Topic info

Board	Causes of male infertility
Started	2h ago
Replies	[n]
Following	[n]

Related information

[Azoospermia explained](#)[Surgical sperm retrieval](#)[Counselling support](#)



This is peer support, not medical advice. Members share their own experience. Talk to your doctor about your own results and options.

Similar topics

High FSH and no sperm: what did your urologist suggest?

Causes of male infertility · [n] replies

Micro-TESE next month: what should I ask the urologist?

Dealing with doctors · [n] replies

Karyotype normal, still waiting on Y-microdeletion results

Causes of male infertility · [n] replies

Feeling like I have let her down

Men's reactions to infertility · [n] replies

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What brings people here

Seeking help for male infertility?

- General discussion



Help with sperm count, low testosterone or sperm motility?

- Causes of male infertility



Trying to understand treatment options?

- Dealing with doctors



Help with gender communication difficulties?

- Women's reactions to male infertility



Boards

[View all](#)

COMMUNITY

- General discussion [n]
- Let off some steam [n]

MEDICAL

- Causes of male infertility [n]
- Dealing with doctors [n]
- Dear Doctor (expert panel) [n]

FEELINGS AND RELATIONSHIPS

- Men's reactions to infertility [n]
- Women's reactions to male infertility [n]

RESEARCH

- Current research on male infertility [n]

Counts show topics per board. Reading is open to everyone; posting needs a free account.

[+ Start a new topic](#)

Discussions

[+ New topic](#)[Latest](#) [Unanswered](#) [Top](#)

	TOPIC	REPLIES	VIEWS	ACTIVITY
DR	Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start? ● Causes of male infertility dan_r	[n] replies	[n] views	2h ago
MT	Micro-TESE next month: what should I ask the urologist? ● Dealing with doctors mark_t	[n] replies	[n] views	5h ago
OA	How do we tell our parents we are using a donor? ● General discussion oakley	[n] replies	[n] views	Yesterday
TH	Second semen analysis came back better. Anyone else? ● Causes of male infertility tomh	[n] replies	[n] views	Yesterday
QO	Feeling like I have let her down ● Men's reactions to infertility quiet_one	[n] replies	[n] views	2 days ago
SK	Another appointment cancelled. I just need to vent ● Let off some steam sam_k	[n] replies	[n] views	2 days ago
LB	How do I support him when he doesn't want to talk about it? ● Women's reactions to male infertility lucy_b	[n] replies	[n] views	3 days ago

[See all latest discussions →](#)[Browse all boards →](#)

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Three steps. No real name, no pressure.

1

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[Join free →](#)

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Share as much or as little as you like. Many members start by reading for a while.

[Go to General discussion →](#)

3

Ask anything

Tests, treatment, how you feel, how to talk to her. Someone here has been there.

[Start a new topic →](#)

Information topics

Our information resources are free for everyone.

[All information →](#)

Male Fertility

How fertility works in men



Infertility

What a diagnosis means



Semen Analysis

Reading your results



Azoospermia

When no sperm are found



Varicocele

Diagnosis and surgery



Treatment

Options explained



Vasectomy Reversal

Reversal surgery



Erection Problems

Causes and help



Egg Donation

Using donor eggs



Sperm Donation

Using or giving donor sperm



Nutrition

Diet and lifestyle



Counselling Support

Someone to talk to



Medical guide

Medical jargon explained in plain words



Emotive guide

The emotional side of male infertility



RESEARCH BOARD

Current research on male infertility

Members share and discuss new studies, trials and news, and help each other make sense of what they mean in practice.

[Open the research board →](#)

RECENTLY DISCUSSED

New paper on sperm DNA fragmentation testing: what do we make of it?

[n] replies · 4h ago

Clinical trials recruiting men: where do you find them?

[n] replies · Yesterday

How to read a research abstract without a science degree

[n] replies · 3 days ago

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Mensfe has been run since 2007 by a counsellor and a scientist who know this ground first-hand.

[About Us and our mission →](#)

PR

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Stronger Together

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mensfe

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Member of iCSI, International Consumer Support for Infertility. Mensfe presented a poster at the ICSI 2007 conference.

FORUM

Latest discussions

All boards

Current research

Forum rules

New member guide

INFORMATION

Azoospermia

Semen Analysis

Treatment

Medical guide

Emotive guide

ABOUT

About Us

Mission

Patrons

Contact

✉ info@mensfe.net

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● Dealing with doctors

Help with gender communication difficulties? →

● Women's reactions to male infertility

Discussions

+ New topic

Latest

Unanswered

Top

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Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

● Causes of male infertility

dan_r

🗨 [n] replies

👁 [n] views

🕒 2h ago

MT

Micro-TESE next month: what should I ask the urologist?

● Dealing with doctors

mark_t

🗨 [n] replies

👁 [n] views

🕒 5h ago

OA

How do we tell our parents we are using a donor?

● General discussion

oakley

🗨 [n] replies

👁 [n] views

🕒 Yesterday

TH

Second semen analysis came back better. Anyone else?

● Causes of male infertility

tomh

🗨 [n] replies

👁 [n] views

🕒 Yesterday

QO

Feeling like I have let her down

● Men's reactions to infertility

quiet_one

🗨 [n] replies

👁 [n] views

🕒 2 days ago

SK

Another appointment cancelled. I just need to vent

● Let off some steam

sam_k

🗨 [n] replies

👁 [n] views

🕒 2 days ago

LB

How do I support him when he doesn't want to talk about it?

● Women's reactions to male infertility

lucy_b

🗨 [n] replies

👁 [n] views

🕒 3 days ago

See all latest discussions →

Browse all boards →

Boards

[View all](#)

● COMMUNITY

● General discussion

[n]

● Let off some steam

[n]

● MEDICAL

● Causes of male infertility

[n]

● Dealing with doctors

[n]

● Dear Doctor (expert panel)

[n]

● FEELINGS AND RELATIONSHIPS

● Men's reactions to infertility

[n]

● Women's reactions to male infertility

[n]

● RESEARCH

● Current research on male infertility

[n]

Counts show topics per board. Reading is open to everyone; posting needs a free account.

+ Start a new topic

New here?

Three steps. No real name, no pressure.

1

Pick an anonymous username

Join free with any name you like. Nobody needs to know who you are.

Join free →

2

Say hello in General discussion

Share as much or as little as you like. Many members start by reading for a while.

Go to General discussion →

3

Ask anything

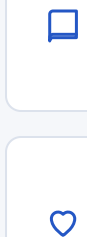
Tests, treatment, how you feel, how to talk to her. Someone here has been there.

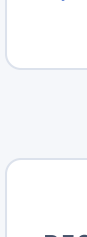
Start a new topic →

Information topics

Our information resources are free for everyone.

[All information →](#)

Male Fertility

Infertility

Semen Analysis

Azoospermia

Varicocele

Treatment

Vasectomy Reversal

Erection Problems

Egg Donation

Sperm Donation

Nutrition

Counselling Support

Medical guide →

Medical jargon explained in plain words

Emotive guide →

The emotional side of male infertility

RESEARCH BOARD

Current research on male infertility

Members share and discuss new studies, trials and news, and help each other make sense of what they mean in practice.

Open the research board →

RECENTLY DISCUSSED

New paper on sperm DNA fragmentation testing: what do we make of it?

[n] replies · 4h ago

Clinical trials recruiting men: where do you find them?

[n] replies · Yesterday

How to read a research abstract without a science degree

[n] replies · 3 days ago

WHO RUNS MENSFE

Started by people who have lived it

Mensfe has been run since 2007 by a counsellor and a scientist who know this ground first-hand.

[About Us and our mission →](#)

PR

Pip Reilly

Co-founder · Fertility counsellor

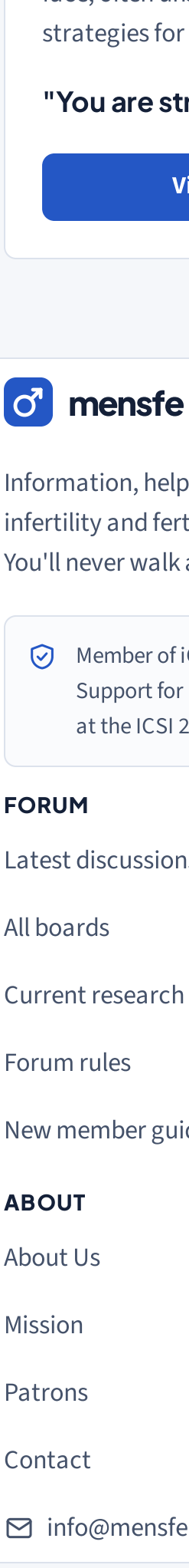
A professional fertility counsellor with over 15 years' experience with fertility charities, and author of *A Journey Through Male Infertility*.

RB

Rob Barlow

Co-founder · Medical scientist

A medical scientist who was diagnosed with azoospermia more than 25 years ago.



THE BOOK

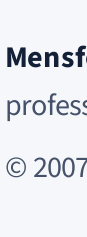
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By Pip Reilly, co-founder of Mensfe

A book for men that women should read. An honest, accessible account of the relational, emotional and physical challenges men face, often unspoken, with practical support strategies for both of you.

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FORUM

Information

Latest discussions

Azoospermia

All boards

Semen Analysis

Current research

Treatment

Forum rules

Medical guide

New member guide

Emotive guide

ABOUT

About Us

Mission

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Every board, grouped by topic. Read freely; join free to post under any username.

Q

Search the forum

Search

+ Start a new topic

Community

TOPICS

POSTS

LAST POST



General discussion
Anything and everything about male fertility.

[n]

topics

[n]

posts

OA

How do we tell our parents we...
by oakley · Yesterday



Let off some steam
Somewhere to vent when it all gets too much.

[n]

topics

[n]

posts

SK

Another appointment cancell...
by sam_k · 2 days ago

Medical

TOPICS

POSTS

LAST POST



Causes of male infertility
Azoospermia, low count, varicocele, hormones and more.

[n]

topics

[n]

posts

DR

Just diagnosed with non-obstr...
by dan_r · 2h ago



Dealing with doctors
Appointments, clinics, tests and treatment.

[n]

topics

[n]

posts

MT

Micro-TESE next month: what s...
by mark_t · 5h ago



Dear Doctor (expert panel)
Questions answered by our medical panel.

[n]

topics

[n]

posts

HH

Is it worth repeating hormone ...
by hopeful_h · 4 days ago

Feelings and relationships

TOPICS

POSTS

LAST POST



Men's reactions to infertility
How it feels, from the men living it.

[n]

topics

[n]

posts

QO

Feeling like I have let her down
by quiet_one · 2 days ago



Women's reactions to male infertility
Partners share their side.

[n]

topics

[n]

posts

LB

How do I support him when he ...
by lucy_b · 3 days ago

Research

TOPICS

POSTS

LAST POST



Current research on male infertility
New studies, trials and news.

[n]

topics

[n]

posts

RK

New paper on sperm DNA frag...
by rob_k · 4h ago

Who's online

[n]

people reading now

Live

[n] members and [n] guests.

Members: dan_r, mark_t, jo_partner, tomh and [n] more.

Forum rules

1. Be kind. Everyone here is going through something hard.

2. Protect privacy: yours, your partner's and other members'.

3. Share experience, not instructions. This is peer support, not medical advice.

4. No advertising or selling.

Read the full rules

→

New member guide

1 Pick an anonymous username.

2 Say hello in General discussion.

3 Ask anything, on any board.

Read the guide

→

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Topics

[n]

Posts

[n]

Members

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Running since

2007

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FORUM

[Latest discussions](#)

[All boards](#)

[Current research](#)

[Forum rules](#)

[New member guide](#)

INFORMATION

[Azoospermia](#)

[Semen Analysis](#)

[Treatment](#)

[Medical guide](#)

[Emotive guide](#)

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[About Us](#)

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Azoospermia

Azoospermia means there is no measurable sperm in the ejaculate. It is a diagnosis many men have never heard of until it is theirs. This guide explains the types, the tests and the routes to parenthood.

Written by [Author name]

Medically reviewed by [Reviewer name, credentials]

Last reviewed [date]

PRRB

Mensfe is run by Pip Reilly, a professional fertility counsellor with over 15 years' experience with fertility charities, and Rob Barlow, a medical scientist who was diagnosed with azoospermia more than 25 years ago.

In short

- Azoospermia means no measurable sperm in the ejaculate. It affects about 1% of all men and around 10–15% of men with infertility.
- There are two main types: **obstructive** (sperm are made but blocked) and **non-obstructive** (the testes make very little or no sperm).
- Diagnosis uses repeat semen analysis, an examination, hormone and genetic blood tests, and sometimes an ultrasound scan.
- Depending on the type, options include surgical repair, sperm retrieval used with ICSI, hormone treatment in some men, or donor sperm.

1 What is azoospermia?

Azoospermia is the medical term for having no measurable sperm in the ejaculate. It affects about 1% of all men, and around 10–15% of men with infertility.

It is usually confirmed by at least two semen analyses. The laboratory spins the sample down (centrifuges it) to look closely for any sperm at all before the result is called azoospermia.

Key facts	
What it means	No measurable sperm in the ejaculate
How common	About 1% of all men; around 10–15% of men with infertility
How it is confirmed	At least two semen analyses, with the sample centrifuged
Main types	Obstructive and non-obstructive
Who to talk to	A urologist or andrologist

2 The two main types

Knowing which type you have matters, because it shapes which treatment options are open to you.

Type 1

Obstructive azoospermia

Sperm are being made, but a blockage stops them reaching the ejaculate.

CAUSES INCLUDE

- A previous vasectomy
- Infection or injury
- Congenital absence of the vas deferens, which is linked to cystic fibrosis gene changes

Type 2

Non-obstructive azoospermia

The testes make very little or no sperm.

CAUSES INCLUDE

- Genetic conditions such as Klinefelter syndrome or Y-chromosome microdeletions
- Hormone problems
- A history of undescended testes
- Previous chemotherapy or radiotherapy

3 How it is diagnosed

Your doctor will usually build up a picture from several tests. You may hear these terms at the clinic:



Repeat semen analysis

To confirm that no sperm are present, including in the centrifuged sample.



Physical examination

A check by a doctor, often a urologist or andrologist.



Hormone blood tests

FSH, LH and testosterone.



Genetic tests

Karyotype, Y-chromosome microdeletion and CFTR (cystic fibrosis gene) testing.



Scrotal ultrasound

Sometimes used to look at the testes and surrounding structures.

4 Treatment options

The options depend on the type of azoospermia and its cause.

Options by type	
TYPE	OPTIONS
Obstructive	Surgical repair, such as vasectomy reversal; or sperm retrieval (PESA, MESA, TESA) used with ICSI
Non-obstructive	In some men, hormone treatment; surgical sperm retrieval such as micro-TESE, used with ICSI
Either type	Donor sperm is another route to parenthood



Talk your options through with a urologist or andrologist. They can explain what your own test results mean for you.

5 You are not alone



[n] members are discussing azoospermia on the forum.

Men who have had this diagnosis, and their partners, share what happened next. Read without an account, or join free under any username.



Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

[n] replies · 2h ago



Karyotype came back normal. Still waiting on the Y-chromosome test

[n] replies · Yesterday



Obstructive after a vasectomy: reversal or retrieval?

[n] replies · 4 days ago

[Go to Causes of male infertility →](#)[Join free](#)

Sources

- [Source 1 — e.g. NHS guidance on azoospermia]
- [Source 2 — e.g. NICE fertility guideline]
- [Source 3 — e.g. WHO laboratory manual for the examination of human semen]
- [Source 4 — e.g. peer-reviewed review article]



Mensfe is peer support. It does not replace personal professional, legal or medical advice. Always talk to a qualified doctor about your own diagnosis and treatment.

Was this page helpful?

☒ Yes☐ No

Still have questions? Members who have been through it can help.

[Ask the community](#)

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Member of ICSI, International Consumer Support for Infertility. Mensfe presented a poster at the ICSI 2007 conference.

FORUM

[Latest discussions](#)[All boards](#)[Current research](#)[Forum rules](#)[New member guide](#)

INFORMATION

[Azoospermia](#)[Semen Analysis](#)[Treatment](#)[Medical guide](#)[Emotive guide](#)

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THE MEN'S FERTILITY FORUM, SINCE 2007

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Information, help and support for male infertility and fertility issues, by you for you. You don't have to work this out on your own.

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6.5 million visits in 2025 Post under any username Free since 2007 Member of iCSI

“

I was exactly where you are three years ago. Write your questions down before the appointment, because you will forget them in the room.

Ask whether they have checked your karyotype and for Y-chromosome microdeletions, because that changed what our options were.

And look after yourself. The first month was the hardest part for me.

mark.t, Causes of male infertility board

Member, replying to a newly diagnosed member

FEATURED MEMBER STORY

In reply to

“Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?”

Read the whole conversation →

Every story on Mensfe is shared under a username. Nobody needs to know who you are to be heard.

Stories from the forum

The latest conversations, in members' own words. Read along, or add your voice when you are ready.

All latest discussions →

Causes of male infertility

Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

Two semen analyses with no sperm found and a high FSH result. Looking for what to ask at the next appointment.

DR dan_r · 2h ago

[n]

General discussion

How do we tell our parents we are using a donor?

We have decided on donor conception and want to share it with family. How did others start that conversation?

OA oakley · Yesterday

[n]

Men's reactions to infertility

Feeling like I have let her down

Since the diagnosis I keep feeling responsible. Has anyone else felt this way, and what helped?

QO quiet_one · 2 days ago

[n]

ALSO NEW **Micro-TESE next month: what should I ask the urologist?** Dealing with doctors · mark.t · 5h ago

Second semen analysis came back better. Anyone else? Causes of male infertility · tomh · Yesterday

Whatever brought you here, there's a board for it

Men arrive with all kinds of questions. Someone here has usually asked yours before.

See the full forum →

Seeking help for male infertility?

Low sperm count, low testosterone or motility?

Trying to understand treatment options?

Finding it hard to talk about?

Community Medical Feelings and relationships Research

General discussion [n] topics

Anything and everything about male fertility.

Causes of male infertility [n] topics

Azoospermia, low count, varicocele, hormones and more.

Dear Doctor (expert panel) [n] topics

Questions answered by our medical panel.

Women's reactions to male infertility [n] topics

Partners share their side.

Let off some steam [n] topics

Somewhere to vent when it all gets too much.

Dealing with doctors [n] topics

Appointments, clinics, tests and treatment.

Men's reactions to infertility [n] topics

How it feels, from the men living it.

Current research on male infertility [n] topics

New studies, trials and news.

Browse all boards

Start a new topic

New here? Start in three small steps

There is no right way to begin. Many members read quietly for weeks before they post, and that is fine too.

@any_name

Only your username is shown

STEP 1

Choose an anonymous username

Join free and pick any name you like. Nobody on the forum needs to know who you are.

Join free →

STEP 2

Say hello

Introduce yourself in General discussion. Share as much or as little as you like.

Go to General discussion →

STEP 3

Ask anything

Tests, treatment, feelings, relationships. Members who have been there will answer from experience.

Start a topic →

Plain-language information

Clear guides to the words, tests and choices you will meet, each linked to the boards where men talk them through.

✓ Our information resources are free for everyone

Medical guide

The jargon, explained

Emotive guide

The emotional side of it

Male fertility

Infertility

Semen analysis

Azoospermia

Varicocele

Treatment

Vasectomy reversal

Erection problems

Egg donation

Sperm donation

Nutrition

Counselling support

RESEARCH BOARD

Current Research On Male Infertility

Members share and discuss new studies, trials and news, and talk about what it might mean for them. A calm place to make sense of the headlines.

Visit the research board →

New studies and clinical trials, shared and discussed by members

Questions to take to your own clinic or consultant

Mensfe is a member of iCSI and presented a poster at the iCSI 2007 conference

WHO RUNS MENSFE

Started by people who have been there

Mensfe is run by a fertility counsellor and a man who has told he had azoospermia. Since 2007 it has been a place for men to be honest about something that often goes unspoken.

About us and our mission →

PR

Pip Reilly

Co-founder · Fertility counsellor

A professional fertility counsellor with over 15 years' experience with fertility charities, and author of *A Journey Through Male Infertility*.

RB

Rob Barlow

Co-founder · Medical scientist

A medical scientist who was diagnosed with azoospermia more than 25 years ago, and knows first-hand what that news feels like.

THE BOOK

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FORUM

All boards

Latest discussions

General discussion

Dear Doctor (expert panel)

Forum rules

INFORMATION

Azoospermia

Semen analysis

Treatment

Counselling support

Medical guide

Emotive guide

ABOUT

About us

Mission

Patrons

Contact

iCSI membership

Home › Forum

The forum

Eight boards, one community. Find the conversation that fits where you are today, or start your own.

Search the forum

 Try “micro-TESE” or “telling family”

Search

+ Start a new topic

 You can read every board without an account. Join free to post.



Community

Say hello, talk about anything, let it out.

2 boards



General discussion

Anything and everything about male fertility.

[n] topics

[n] posts

LAST POST

How do we tell our parents we are using a donor?

by oakley · Yesterday



Let off some steam

Somewhere to vent when it all gets too much.

[n] topics

[n] posts

LAST POST

Another pregnancy announcement at work today

by sam_k · 3h ago

Who’s online

[n] members and [n] guests are reading right now.

DR

MT

OA

QO

+

dan_r, mark_t, oakley, quiet_one and [n] others

New member guide

Three small steps to your first post.

1

Join free and choose an anonymous username.

2

Say hello in General discussion.

3

Ask anything. Someone has been there.

Read the full guide



Medical

Causes, tests, doctors and treatment.

3 boards



Causes of male infertility

Azoospermia, low count, varicocele, hormones and more.

[n] topics

[n] posts

LAST POST

Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

by dan_r · 2h ago



Dealing with doctors

Appointments, clinics, tests and treatment.

[n] topics

[n] posts

LAST POST

Micro-TESE next month: what should I ask the urologist?

by mark_t · 5h ago



Dear Doctor (expert panel)

Questions answered by our medical panel.

Expert answers

[n] topics

[n] posts

LAST POST

Does a high FSH result change what retrieval can find?

by ali_h · 3 days ago

Forum rules

1

Be kind. Everyone here is going through something.

2

Protect your privacy and other people’s.

3

Share experience, not medical instructions.

4

No advertising or promotion of clinics or products.

Read all forum rules →



Feelings and relationships

How infertility feels, for men and for the people beside them.

2 boards



Men’s reactions to infertility

How it feels, from the men living it.

[n] topics

[n] posts

LAST POST

Feeling like I have let her down

by quiet_one · 2 days ago



Women’s reactions to male infertility

Partners share their side.

[n] topics

[n] posts

LAST POST

How do I support him when he doesn’t want to talk?

by jo_partner · 4 days ago

Need to talk to someone?

Mensfe is peer support. Our Counselling Support page lists services if you would like professional help.

Counselling support



Research

What is new in the science, discussed calmly.

1 board



Current research on male infertility

New studies, trials and news.

[n] topics

[n] posts

LAST POST

Has anyone read the latest paper on micro-TESE?

by tomh · 1 week ago

Causes of male infertility

Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

Started by **dan_r**

2h ago

[n] replies

[n] views

-  Reply
-  Follow
-  Share

**dan_r**

Member

Original post

Joined [date] · [n] posts

2h ago

My wife and I got the results last week. Two semen analyses, both showed no sperm at all, and the consultant thinks it is probably non-obstructive. My FSH came back high.

I honestly don't know what to feel. I keep reading about micro-TESE and success rates and it is all a blur. If anyone has been through this, what should we be asking at the next appointment?

 Helpful [n]

 Support [n]

 Quote

 [Reply](#)

Topic info

Board

[Causes of male infertility](#)

Started

2h ago

Replies

[n]

Following

[n]

Related information

Azoospermia explained

→

Surgical sperm retrieval

→

Counselling support

→

Replies

[n] so far

**mark_t**

Member

Joined [date] · [n] posts

1h ago

I was exactly where you are three years ago. Write your questions down before the appointment, because you will forget them in the room. Ask whether they have checked your karyotype and for Y-chromosome microdeletions, because that changed what our options were.

And look after yourself. The first month was the hardest part for me.

 Helpful [n]

 Support [n]

 Quote

 [Reply](#)

**Mensfe Team**

Moderator

Joined [date] · [n] posts

45m ago

Welcome, and thank you for posting. A lot of men read this board without ever writing, so this will help others too. Our [Azoospermia guide](#) explains the tests and treatment terms you will hear, and the [Counselling Support page](#) lists services if you would like to talk to someone.

 Helpful [n]

 Support [n]

 Quote

 [Reply](#)

**jo_partner**

Partner

Joined [date] · [n] posts

20m ago

Wife of a member here. It is not your fault, and she is probably as worried about you as about the result. Talking to each other helped us more than anything the clinic said.

 Helpful [n]

 Support [n]

 Quote

 [Reply](#)

Add your voice

A few kind words can mean a lot to someone who has just had this news. Share what helped you, or simply let dan_r know he is not alone.

Your reply

 **B**

 *I*

 [Link](#)

Write as you would to a friend. You can post under any username.

☒ Notify me of replies

[Post reply](#) →

You will need to [sign in](#) or [join free](#) to post. Reading is always free.

 **A gentle note**

This is peer support, not medical advice. Members share their own experience; please talk decisions through with your doctor.

Similar topics

Micro-TESE next month: what should I ask the urologist?

Dealing with doctors · [n] replies

Waiting for genetic test results

Causes of male infertility · [n] replies

Obstructive after vasectomy: reversal or retrieval?

Causes of male infertility · [n] replies

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FORUM

All boards

Latest discussions

General discussion

Dear Doctor (expert panel)

Forum rules

INFORMATION

Azoospermia

Semen analysis

Treatment

Counselling support

Medical guide

Emotive guide

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About us

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Azoospermia

Azoospermia means there is no measurable sperm in the ejaculate. It is hard news to hear, but it has known causes, clear tests and more than one possible route forward. This guide explains it in plain language.

 WRITTEN BY
[Author name]

 MEDICALLY REVIEWED BY
[Reviewer name, credentials]

 LAST REVIEWED
[Last reviewed date]

Mensfe is run by Pip Reilly, a professional fertility counsellor with over 15 years' experience with fertility charities, and Rob Barlow, a medical scientist who was diagnosed with azoospermia more than 25 years ago. [About us](#)

ON THIS PAGE

- 01What is azoospermia?
- 02The two main types
- 03How it is diagnosed
- 04Treatment options
- 05You are not alone
- 06Sources

Have a question this page doesn't answer?

06Ask the community

In short

- ✓ Azoospermia means no measurable sperm in the ejaculate. It is usually confirmed by at least two semen analyses.
- ✓ It affects about 1% of all men and around 10–15% of men with infertility.
- ✓ There are two main types: obstructive (sperm are made but blocked) and non-obstructive (the testes make very little or no sperm).
- ✓ Depending on the cause, options include surgical repair, sperm retrieval used with ICSI, hormone treatment for some men, or donor sperm.

What is azoospermia?

Azoospermia is the medical term for having no measurable sperm in the ejaculate. Many men only find out when they have a semen analysis as part of fertility tests.

1%

of all men are affected by azoospermia.
That rises to around 10–15% of men with infertility.

A single result is not enough for a diagnosis. Azoospermia is usually confirmed by at least two semen analyses, with the sample spun down (centrifuged) so the laboratory can look carefully for any sperm at all.

The two main types

Doctors divide azoospermia into two groups, because the cause shapes which treatments make sense.

OBSTRUCTIVE

Sperm are made, but blocked

The testes produce sperm, but a blockage stops them reaching the ejaculate.

Causes include a previous vasectomy, infection or injury, or congenital absence of the vas deferens, which is linked to cystic fibrosis gene changes.

NON-OBSTRUCTIVE

Very little or no sperm made

The testes make very little or no sperm.

Causes include genetic conditions such as Klinefelter syndrome or Y-chromosome microdeletions, hormone problems, a history of undescended testes, or previous chemotherapy or radiotherapy.

“

Write your questions down before the appointment, because you will forget them in the room.

mark_t, on the [Causes of male infertility board](#)

How it is diagnosed

Working out the type and cause usually involves several steps. Your doctor may suggest some or all of these:

 **Repeat semen analysis**
At least two samples, centrifuged and examined.

 **Physical examination**
Including the testes and the vas deferens.

 **Hormone blood tests**
FSH, LH and testosterone.

 **Genetic tests**
Karyotype, Y-chromosome microdeletion and CFTR.

 **Scrotal ultrasound**
Sometimes, to look at the testes and surrounding structures.

 Questions you might take to your appointment

- Do you think my azoospermia is obstructive or non-obstructive, and why?
- Which hormone tests have been done, and what did they show?
- Have I had a karyotype, Y-chromosome microdeletion and CFTR test?
- Would a scrotal ultrasound help in my case?

Treatment options

The right option depends on the type and cause. These are the main routes you are likely to hear about.

OBSTRUCTIVE

Repair or retrieve

Surgical repair of the blockage, such as vasectomy reversal.

Or sperm retrieval (PESA, MESA or TESA), with the sperm used in ICSI.

NON-OBSTRUCTIVE

Hormones or micro-TESE

In some men, hormone treatment.

Surgical sperm retrieval such as micro-TESE, with any sperm found used in ICSI.

Donor sperm is another route to parenthood, and some couples consider it alongside or after other options.

Every situation is different. Talk your options through with a urologist or andrologist, who can explain what is realistic for you.

FROM THE FORUM

You are not alone

[n] members are discussing azoospermia on the Causes of male infertility board. Read their stories, or ask your own question under any username.

Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

dan_r · 2h ago

Waiting for genetic test results

[n] replies

Obstructive after vasectomy: reversal or retrieval?

[n] replies

Visit the board →

Ask the community

Sources

1. [Source 1 — e.g. NHS / NICE / WHO guidance]
2. [Source 2 — e.g. professional society guideline on male infertility]
3. [Source 3 — e.g. peer-reviewed review article]

 **Disclaimer.** Mensfe is peer support. It does not replace personal professional, legal or medical advice. Always discuss your own results and options with a qualified clinician.

Was this page helpful?

✓ Yes

✗ No

Related information

Semen analysis

Treatment

Vasectomy reversal

Sperm donation

Counselling support



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 **ANNOUNCEMENT** New to Mensfe? Read the new-member guide and forum rules before posting.

Mensfe Forum

Mensfe Forum

A free, anonymous peer-support forum for men facing infertility, and the partners who stand with them. Read any board without an account.

 New here?

1 Pick an anonymous username.
Registering is free and nobody needs your real name.

2 Say hello in General discussion.
Share as much or as little as you like.

3 Ask anything. Someone here has usually been through it. Not ready? Just read.

[New-member guide](#) · [Forum rules](#)

 TRENDING NOW



Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start? [Causes of male infertility](#)



Micro-TESE next month: what should I ask the urologist? [Dealing with doctors](#)



How do we tell our parents we are using a donor? [General discussion](#)



Feeling like I have let her down [Men's reactions](#)



COMMUNITY



BOARD

TOPICS

POSTS

LAST POST



General discussion

Anything and everything about male fertility.

Moderator: **Mensfe Team**

[n]

[n]

How do we tell our parents we are using a ...
by oakley · Yesterday



Let off some steam

Somewhere to vent when it all gets too much.

[n]

[n]

Another pregnancy announcement at work
by [username] · 3 days ago



Information guides

Plain-English guides to tests, causes and treatment, written for Mensfe members.

Redirects: [n]

Redirects to the Information section



MEDICAL



BOARD

TOPICS

POSTS

LAST POST



Causes of male infertility

Azoospermia, low count, varicocele, hormones and more.

Child boards: **Azoospermia** **Low count** **Varicocele** **Hormones**

Moderator: **Mensfe Team**

[n]

[n]

Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoo...
by dan_r · 2h ago



Dealing with doctors

Appointments, clinics, tests and treatment.

[n]

[n]

Micro-TESE next month: what should I ask...
by mark_t · 5h ago



Dear Doctor (expert panel)

Questions answered by our medical panel.

Moderator: **Medical panel**

[n]

[n]

Does a varicocele affect sperm DNA?
by [username] · 4 days ago



FEELINGS AND RELATIONSHIPS



BOARD

TOPICS

POSTS

LAST POST



Men's reactions to infertility

How it feels, from the men living it.

[n]

[n]

Feeling like I have let her down
by quiet_one · 2 days ago



Women's reactions to male infertility

Partners share their side.

[n]

[n]

How do I support him without pushing?
by jo_partner · 3 days ago



RESEARCH



BOARD

TOPICS

POSTS

LAST POST



Current research on male infertility

New studies, trials and news.

[n]

[n]

Discussion thread: recent papers on sper...
by Mensfe Team · 5 days ago



New posts



No new posts



Redirect board



RECENT POSTS

View all

TOPIC

BOARD

STARTED BY

WHEN

Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

[Causes of male infertility](#)

[dan_r](#)

2h ago

Micro-TESE next month: what should I ask the urologist?

[Dealing with doctors](#)

[mark_t](#)

5h ago

How do we tell our parents we are using a donor?

[General discussion](#)

[oakley](#)

Yesterday

Second semen analysis came back better. Anyone else?

[Causes of male infertility](#)

[tomh](#)

Yesterday

Feeling like I have let her down

[Men's reactions to infertility](#)

[quiet_one](#)

2 days ago



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Members: [dan_r](#), [mark_t](#), [oakley](#), [tomh](#), [quiet_one](#), [jo_partner](#)

Users active in the past 15 minutes.



Who runs Mensfe

Founded by **Pip Reilly**, a professional fertility counsellor with over 15 years' experience with fertility charities, and **Rob Barlow**, a medical scientist diagnosed with azoospermia more than 25 years ago.

Pip's book: A Journey Through Male Infertility: Stronger Together.

Member of iCSI, International Consumer Support for Infertility.

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Entire forum

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Mensfe Forum

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Ask anything. Someone here has usually been through it. Not ready? Just read.

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🔥 TRENDING NOW

🔍

Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

Causes of male infertility

👤

Micro-TESE next month: what should I ask the urologist?

Dealing with doctors

💬

How do we tell our parents we are using a donor?

General discussion

❤️

Feeling like I have let her down

Men's reactions

💬 COMMUNITY

💬

General discussion

Anything and everything about male fertility.
Moderator: **Mensfe Team**
[n] topics · [n] posts

Last post: **How do we tell our parents we are using a donor?** by oakley · Yesterday

👤

Let off some steam

Somewhere to vent when it all gets too much.
[n] topics · [n] posts

Last post: **Another pregnancy announcement at work** by [username] · 3 days ago

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Information guides

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🏥 MEDICAL

🔍

Causes of male infertility

Azoospermia, low count, varicocele, hormones and more.
Child boards:

● Azoospermia ● Low count ● Varicocele ● Hormones

Moderator: **Mensfe Team**
[n] topics · [n] posts

Last post: **Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?** by dan_r · 2h ago

👤

Dealing with doctors

Appointments, clinics, tests and treatment.
[n] topics · [n] posts

Last post: **Micro-TESE next month: what should I ask the urologist?** by mark_t · 5h ago

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Dear Doctor (expert panel)

Questions answered by our medical panel.
Moderator: **Medical panel**
[n] topics · [n] posts

Last post: **Does a varicocele affect sperm DNA?** by [username] · 4 days ago

❤️ FEELINGS AND RELATIONSHIPS

❤️

Men's reactions to infertility

How it feels, from the men living it.
[n] topics · [n] posts

Last post: **Feeling like I have let her down** by quiet_one · 2 days ago

👤

Women's reactions to male infertility

Partners share their side.
[n] topics · [n] posts

Last post: **How do I support him without pushing?** by jo_partner · 3 days ago

🧪 RESEARCH

🧪

Current research on male infertility

New studies, trials and news.
[n] topics · [n] posts

Last post: **Discussion thread: recent papers on sperm retrieval** by Mensfe Team · 5 days ago

💬

New posts

💬

No new posts

➡️

Redirect board

💬 RECENT POSTS

Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

Board: Causes of male infertility · by dan_r · 2h ago

Micro-TESE next month: what should I ask the urologist?

Board: Dealing with doctors · by mark_t · 5h ago

How do we tell our parents we are using a donor?

Board: General discussion · by oakley · Yesterday

Second semen analysis came back better. Anyone else?

Board: Causes of male infertility · by tomh · Yesterday

Feeling like I have let her down

Board: Men's reactions to infertility · by quiet_one · 2 days ago

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Users active in the past 15 minutes.

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Pip's book: [A Journey Through Male Infertility: Stronger Together](#).
Member of iCSI, International Consumer Support for Infertility.



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ANNOUNCEMENT New to Mensfe? Read the new-member guide and forum rules before posting.

Mensfe Forum > Medical > Causes of male infertility



Causes of male infertility

Azoospermia, low count, varicocele, hormones and more. Share test results, ask what they mean and compare notes with men who have had the same diagnosis.

Moderators: [Mensfe Team](#) · [Medical panel](#)



CHILD BOARDS



BOARD	TOPICS	POSTS	LAST POST
Azoospermia Obstructive and non-obstructive, sperm retrieval, next steps.	[n]	[n]	Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoo... by dan_r · 2h ago
Low sperm count Count, motility and morphology, and what the numbers mean.	[n]	[n]	Second semen analysis came back better. ... by tomh · Yesterday
Varicocele Diagnosis, surgery and recovery.	[n]	[n]	Varicocele repair: did your numbers impro... by [username] · 2 days ago
Hormones and testosterone Low T, FSH, LH and hormone treatment.	[n]	[n]	Anyone tried clomiphene for low testoster... by [username] · 3 days ago

Pages:

1

2

3

...

[n]

→

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TOPICS

Sorted by last post

SUBJECT / STARTED BY	REPLIES / VIEWS	LAST POST
READ FIRST: Board guidelines and useful links Pinned Locked Started by Mensfe Team	[n] Replies [n] Views	READ FIRST: Board guidelines and useful l... by Mensfe Team · [date]
Azoospermia: frequently asked questions Pinned Started by Mensfe Team « 1 2 »	[n] Replies [n] Views	Azoospermia: frequently asked questions by mark_t · Yesterday
Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start? New Started by dan_r	[n] Replies [n] Views	Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoo... by jo_partner · 2h ago
Second semen analysis came back better. Anyone else? Started by tomh	[n] Replies [n] Views	Second semen analysis came back better. ... by tomh · Yesterday
Karyotype normal, still waiting on Y-microdeletion results Started by sam_k	[n] Replies [n] Views	Karyotype normal, still waiting on Y-micro... by mark_t · Yesterday
High FSH and no sperm: what did your urologist suggest? Started by rich_w	[n] Replies [n] Views	High FSH and no sperm: what did your uro... by dan_r · 2 days ago
Varicocele repair: did your numbers improve? Hot Started by lee_b « 1 2 »	[n] Replies [n] Views	Varicocele repair: did your numbers impro... by [username] · 2 days ago
Obstructive after vasectomy: PESA or reversal? Started by pete_m	[n] Replies [n] Views	Obstructive after vasectomy: PESA or reve... by [username] · 3 days ago
Anyone tried clomiphene for low testosterone? Started by gaz77	[n] Replies [n] Views	Anyone tried clomiphene for low testoster... by [username] · 3 days ago
Low motility on two tests: what changes helped you? Started by andy_c	[n] Replies [n] Views	Low motility on two tests: what changes h... by tomh · 4 days ago
Klinefelter diagnosis in my thirties: where next? Started by [username]	[n] Replies [n] Views	Klinefelter diagnosis in my thirties: where ... by Mensfe Team · 5 days ago
Morphology at 1%: should we be worried? Started by nick_s	[n] Replies [n] Views	Morphology at 1%: should we be worried? by [username] · [date]

Pages:

1

2

3

...

[n]

→

+ New topic

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New posts



No new posts



Pinned Pinned topic



Locked Locked topic



Hot Hot topic (many replies)

Jump to:

Causes of male infertility



Go

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📣 **ANNOUNCEMENT** New to Mensfe? Read the new-member guide and forum rules before posting.

Mensfe Forum > Causes of male infertility > **Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?**

Pages:

1

↩ Reply

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🕒 Mark unread

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AUTHOR

DR

dan_r

OP

Newbie

Progress bar

Posts: [n]
[location]
Joined: [date]

TOPIC · CAUSES OF MALE INFERTILITY

Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

Read [n] times · [n] replies · started by dan_r

Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

« on: [date, time] »

🗣 Quote

↩ Reply

My wife and I got the results last week. Two semen analyses, both showed no sperm at all, and the consultant thinks it is probably non-obstructive. My FSH came back high.

I honestly don't know what to feel. I keep reading about micro-TESE and success rates and it is all a blur. If anyone has been through this, what should we be asking at the next appointment?

👍 Helpful [n]

💖 Support [n]

👤 Same here [n]

📧 Report to moderator

🕒 Logged

MT

mark_t

Full Member

Progress bar

Posts: [n]
[location]
Joined: [date]

Re: Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

« Reply #1 on: [date, time] »

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↩ Reply

🗣 Quote from: [dan_r](#) on [date, time]

what should we be asking at the next appointment?

I was exactly where you are three years ago. Write your questions down before the appointment, because you will forget them in the room. Ask whether they have checked your karyotype and for Y-chromosome microdeletions, because that changed what our options were.

And look after yourself. The first month was the hardest part for me.

👍 Helpful [n]

💖 Support [n]

👤 Same here [n]

Diagnosed 2023 · micro-TESE 2024 · one day at a time

📧 Report to moderator

🕒 Logged

M

Mensfe Team

Moderator

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Posts: [n]
Mensfe
Joined: [date]

Re: Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

« Reply #2 on: [date, time] »

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Welcome, and thank you for posting. A lot of men read this board without ever writing, so this will help others too. Our [Azoospermia guide](#) explains the tests and treatment terms you will hear, and the [Counselling Support page](#) lists services if you would like to talk to someone.

👍 Helpful [n]

💖 Support [n]

👤 Same here [n]

Mensfe is peer support. It does not replace personal professional, legal or medical advice.

📧 Report to moderator

🕒 Logged

JP

jo_partner

Partner

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Posts: [n]
[location]
Joined: [date]

Re: Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

« Reply #3 on: [date, time] »

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↩ Reply

Wife of a member here. It is not your fault, and she is probably as worried about you as about the result. Talking to each other helped us more than anything the clinic said.

👍 Helpful [n]

💖 Support [n]

👤 Same here [n]

Partner of a Mensfe member · stronger together

📧 Report to moderator

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🗣

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📢 **This is peer support, not medical advice.** Members share their own experience. Please talk to your doctor, urologist or clinic about your own diagnosis and treatment. Read the forum rules.

 **INFORMATION**

 Male fertility

 Infertility

 Semen analysis

 **Azoospermia**

 Varicocele

 Treatment

 Vasectomy reversal

 Erection problems

 Egg donation

 Sperm donation

 Nutrition

 Counselling support

 Medical guide (jargon explained)

 Emotive guide

 **ON THIS PAGE**

1 What is azoospermia?

2 The two main types

3 How it is diagnosed

4 Treatment options

5 Discuss this on the forum

6 Sources

INFORMATION GUIDE · CAUSES OF MALE INFERTILITY

Azoospermia

What it means when a semen analysis finds no sperm, the two main types, the tests you are likely to have and the routes to parenthood that are open to you.

 Written by [Author name]

 Medically reviewed by [Reviewer name, credentials]

 Last reviewed [date]

Mensfe is run by **Pip Reilly**, a professional fertility counsellor with over 15 years' experience with fertility charities, and **Rob Barlow**, a medical scientist who was diagnosed with azoospermia more than 25 years ago.

 IN SHORT

- Azoospermia means no measurable sperm in the ejaculate. It affects about 1% of all men and around 10–15% of men with infertility.
- It is either **obstructive** (sperm are made but blocked) or **non-obstructive** (the testes make very little or no sperm).
- Many men can still become fathers, through surgery, sperm retrieval with ICSI, or donor sperm.

What is azoospermia?

Azoospermia means there is no measurable sperm in the ejaculate. It affects about 1% of all men and around 10–15% of men with infertility.

It is usually confirmed by at least two semen analyses, with the sample spun down (centrifuged) so the laboratory can look for any sperm at all.

The two main types

OBSTRUCTIVE

Sperm are made, but blocked

A blockage stops sperm reaching the ejaculate. This can happen after a vasectomy, an infection or an injury, or because of congenital absence of the vas deferens, which is linked to cystic fibrosis gene changes.

NON-OBSTRUCTIVE

Very little or no sperm is made

The testes make very little or no sperm. Causes include genetic conditions such as Klinefelter syndrome or Y-chromosome microdeletions, hormone problems, a history of undescended testes, or previous chemotherapy or radiotherapy.

How it is diagnosed

- Repeat semen analysis**, with the sample centrifuged to look for any sperm.
- Physical examination** by a urologist or andrologist.
- Hormone blood tests**: FSH, LH and testosterone.
- Genetic tests**: karyotype, Y-chromosome microdeletion and CFTR (the cystic fibrosis gene).
- Sometimes a **scrotal ultrasound**.

Treatment options

Obstructive azoospermia

Surgical repair, such as vasectomy reversal, or sperm retrieval (PESA, MESA or TESA) with the sperm then used in ICSI.

Non-obstructive azoospermia

In some men, hormone treatment. Surgical sperm retrieval, such as micro-TESE, with any sperm found used in ICSI.

Donor sperm

Donor sperm is another route to parenthood. Many couples consider it alongside, or after, other options.

Talk your options through with a urologist or andrologist, who can explain what fits your test results.



DISCUSS THIS ON THE FORUM From Causes of male infertility · [n] members discussing

	SUBJECT / STARTED BY	REPLIES / VIEWS	LAST POST
 	Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start? Started by dan_r	[n] Replies [n] Views	Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoo... by jo_partner · 2h ago
	High FSH and no sperm: what did your urologist suggest? Started by rich_w	[n] Replies [n] Views	High FSH and no sperm: what did your uro... by dan_r · 2 days ago
 	Karyotype normal, still waiting on Y-microdeletion results Started by sam_k	[n] Replies [n] Views	Karyotype normal, still waiting on Y-micro... by mark_t · Yesterday

You are not alone. Men who have had this diagnosis answer questions here every day.

View the board

 Ask the community: start a topic

Sources

- [Source 1, e.g. NHS / NICE / WHO guidance]
- [Source 2, e.g. clinical guideline on male infertility]
- [Source 3, e.g. peer-reviewed review article]

Was this page helpful?

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TRENDING NOW



Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start? Causes of male infertility



Micro-TESE next month: what should I ask the urologist? Dealing with doctors



How do we tell our parents we are using a donor? General discussion



Feeling like I have let her down Men's reactions



COMMUNITY



BOARD	TOPICS	POSTS	LAST POST
 General discussion Anything and everything about male fertility. Moderator: Mensfe Team	[n]	[n]	How do we tell our parents we are using a ... by oakley · Yesterday
 Let off some steam Somewhere to vent when it all gets too much.	[n]	[n]	Another pregnancy announcement at work by [username] · 3 days ago
 Information guides Plain-English guides to tests, causes and treatment, written for Mensfe members.	Redirects: [n]		Redirects to the Information section



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BOARD	TOPICS	POSTS	LAST POST
 Causes of male infertility Azoospermia, low count, varicocele, hormones and more. Child boards: Azoospermia Low count Varicocele Hormones Moderator: Mensfe Team	[n]	[n]	Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoo... by dan_r · 2h ago
 Dealing with doctors Appointments, clinics, tests and treatment.	[n]	[n]	Micro-TESE next month: what should I ask... by mark_t · 5h ago
 Dear Doctor (expert panel) Questions answered by our medical panel. Moderator: Medical panel	[n]	[n]	Does a varicocele affect sperm DNA? by [username] · 4 days ago



FEELINGS AND RELATIONSHIPS



BOARD	TOPICS	POSTS	LAST POST
 Men's reactions to infertility How it feels, from the men living it.	[n]	[n]	Feeling like I have let her down by quiet_one · 2 days ago
 Women's reactions to male infertility Partners share their side.	[n]	[n]	How do I support him without pushing? by jo_partner · 3 days ago



RESEARCH



BOARD	TOPICS	POSTS	LAST POST
 Current research on male infertility New studies, trials and news.	[n]	[n]	Discussion thread: recent papers on sper... by Mensfe Team · 5 days ago



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TOPIC	BOARD	STARTED BY	WHEN
Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?	Causes of male infertility	dan_r	2h ago
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How do we tell our parents we are using a donor?	General discussion	oakley	Yesterday
Second semen analysis came back better. Anyone else?	Causes of male infertility	tomh	Yesterday
Feeling like I have let her down	Men's reactions to infertility	quiet_one	2 days ago



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Members: **dan_r, mark_t, oakley, tomh, quiet_one, jo_partner**

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Who runs Mensfe

Founded by **Pip Reilly**, a professional fertility counsellor with over 15 years' experience with fertility charities, and **Rob Barlow**, a medical scientist diagnosed with azoospermia more than 25 years ago.

Pip's book: *A Journey Through Male Infertility: Stronger Together*.

Member of iCSI, International Consumer Support for Infertility.



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ANNOUNCEMENT New to Mensfe? Read the [new-member guide](#) and [forum rules](#) before posting.

Mensfe Forum > Medical > Causes of male infertility



Causes of male infertility

Azoospermia, low count, varicocele, hormones and more. Share test results, ask what they mean and compare notes with men who have had the same diagnosis.

Moderators: [Mensfe Team](#) · [Medical panel](#)



CHILD BOARDS



BOARD	TOPICS	POSTS	LAST POST
Azoospermia Obstructive and non-obstructive, sperm retrieval, next steps.	[n]	[n]	Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoo... by dan_r · 2h ago
Low sperm count Count, motility and morphology, and what the numbers mean.	[n]	[n]	Second semen analysis came back better. ... by tomh · Yesterday
Varicocele Diagnosis, surgery and recovery.	[n]	[n]	Varicocele repair: did your numbers impro... by [username] · 2 days ago
Hormones and testosterone Low T, FSH, LH and hormone treatment.	[n]	[n]	Anyone tried clomiphene for low testoster... by [username] · 3 days ago

Pages:

1

2

3

...

[n]



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TOPICS

Sorted by last post

SUBJECT / STARTED BY	REPLIES / VIEWS	LAST POST
READ FIRST: Board guidelines and useful links Pinned Locked Started by Mensfe Team	[n] Replies [n] Views	READ FIRST: Board guidelines and useful l... by Mensfe Team · [date]
Azoospermia: frequently asked questions Pinned Started by Mensfe Team « 1 2 »	[n] Replies [n] Views	Azoospermia: frequently asked questions by mark_t · Yesterday
Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start? New Started by dan_r	[n] Replies [n] Views	Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoo... by jo_partner · 2h ago
Second semen analysis came back better. Anyone else? Started by tomh	[n] Replies [n] Views	Second semen analysis came back better. ... by tomh · Yesterday
Karyotype normal, still waiting on Y-microdeletion results Started by sam_k	[n] Replies [n] Views	Karyotype normal, still waiting on Y-micro... by mark_t · Yesterday
High FSH and no sperm: what did your urologist suggest? Started by rich_w	[n] Replies [n] Views	High FSH and no sperm: what did your uro... by dan_r · 2 days ago
Varicocele repair: did your numbers improve? Hot Started by lee_b « 1 2 »	[n] Replies [n] Views	Varicocele repair: did your numbers impro... by [username] · 2 days ago
Obstructive after vasectomy: PESA or reversal? Started by pete_m	[n] Replies [n] Views	Obstructive after vasectomy: PESA or reve... by [username] · 3 days ago
Anyone tried clomiphene for low testosterone? Started by gaz77	[n] Replies [n] Views	Anyone tried clomiphene for low testoster... by [username] · 3 days ago
Low motility on two tests: what changes helped you? Started by andy_c	[n] Replies [n] Views	Low motility on two tests: what changes h... by tomh · 4 days ago
Klinefelter diagnosis in my thirties: where next? Started by [username]	[n] Replies [n] Views	Klinefelter diagnosis in my thirties: where ... by Mensfe Team · 5 days ago
Morphology at 1%: should we be worried? Started by nick_s	[n] Replies [n] Views	Morphology at 1%: should we be worried? by [username] · [date]

Pages:

1

2

3

...

[n]



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Causes of male infertility



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 **ANNOUNCEMENT** New to Mensfe? Read the [new-member guide](#) and [forum rules](#) before posting.

Mensfe Forum > Causes of male infertility > **Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?**

Pages:

1

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TOPIC · CAUSES OF MALE INFERTILITY

Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

Read [n] times · [n] replies · started by dan_r

DR

dan_r

OP

Newbie

Posts: [n]

[location]

Joined: [date]

Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

« on: [date, time] »

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My wife and I got the results last week. Two semen analyses, both showed no sperm at all, and the consultant thinks it is probably non-obstructive. My FSH came back high.

I honestly don't know what to feel. I keep reading about micro-TESE and success rates and it is all a blur. If anyone has been through this, what should we be asking at the next appointment?

Helpful [n]

Support [n]

Same here [n]

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mark_t

Full Member

Posts: [n]

[location]

Joined: [date]

Re: Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

« Reply #1 on: [date, time] »

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Quote from: dan_r on [date, time]

what should we be asking at the next appointment?

I was exactly where you are three years ago. Write your questions down before the appointment, because you will forget them in the room. Ask whether they have checked your karyotype and for Y-chromosome microdeletions, because that changed what our options were.

And look after yourself. The first month was the hardest part for me.

Helpful [n]

Support [n]

Same here [n]

Diagnosed 2023 · micro-TESE 2024 · one day at a time

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Mensfe Team

Moderator

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Mensfe

Joined: [date]

Re: Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

« Reply #2 on: [date, time] »

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Welcome, and thank you for posting. A lot of men read this board without ever writing, so this will help others too. Our [Azoospermia guide](#) explains the tests and treatment terms you will hear, and the [Counselling Support page](#) lists services if you would like to talk to someone.

Helpful [n]

Support [n]

Same here [n]

Mensfe is peer support. It does not replace personal professional, legal or medical advice.

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JP

jo_partner

Partner

Junior Member

Posts: [n]

[location]

Joined: [date]

Re: Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start?

« Reply #3 on: [date, time] »

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Wife of a member here. It is not your fault, and she is probably as worried about you as about the result. Talking to each other helped us more than anything the clinic said.

Helpful [n]

Support [n]

Same here [n]

Partner of a Mensfe member · stronger together

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1

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 **This is peer support, not medical advice.** Members share their own experience. Please talk to your doctor, urologist or clinic about your own diagnosis and treatment. Read the forum rules.

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 INFORMATION

 Male fertility

 Infertility

 Semen analysis

 **Azoospermia**

 Varicocele

 Treatment

 Vasectomy reversal

 Erection problems

 Egg donation

 Sperm donation

 Nutrition

 Counselling support

 Medical guide (jargon explained)

 Emotive guide

 ON THIS PAGE

1

What is azoospermia?

2

The two main types

3

How it is diagnosed

4

Treatment options

5

Discuss this on the forum

6

Sources

INFORMATION GUIDE · CAUSES OF MALE INFERTILITY

Azoospermia

What it means when a semen analysis finds no sperm, the two main types, the tests you are likely to have and the routes to parenthood that are open to you.

 Written by [Author name]  Medically reviewed by [Reviewer name, credentials]  Last reviewed [date]

Mensfe is run by **Pip Reilly**, a professional fertility counsellor with over 15 years' experience with fertility charities, and **Rob Barlow**, a medical scientist who was diagnosed with azoospermia more than 25 years ago.

 IN SHORT

- Azoospermia means no measurable sperm in the ejaculate. It affects about 1% of all men and around 10–15% of men with infertility.
- It is either **obstructive** (sperm are made but blocked) or **non-obstructive** (the testes make very little or no sperm).
- Many men can still become fathers, through surgery, sperm retrieval with ICSI, or donor sperm.

What is azoospermia?

Azoospermia means there is no measurable sperm in the ejaculate. It affects about 1% of all men and around 10–15% of men with infertility.

It is usually confirmed by at least two semen analyses, with the sample spun down (centrifuged) so the laboratory can look for any sperm at all.

The two main types

OBSTRUCTIVE

Sperm are made, but blocked

A blockage stops sperm reaching the ejaculate. This can happen after a vasectomy, an infection or an injury, or because of congenital absence of the vas deferens, which is linked to cystic fibrosis gene changes.

NON-OBSTRUCTIVE

Very little or no sperm is made

The testes make very little or no sperm. Causes include genetic conditions such as Klinefelter syndrome or Y-chromosome microdeletions, hormone problems, a history of undescended testes, or previous chemotherapy or radiotherapy.

How it is diagnosed

- Repeat semen analysis**, with the sample centrifuged to look for any sperm.
- Physical examination** by a urologist or andrologist.
- Hormone blood tests**: FSH, LH and testosterone.
- Genetic tests**: karyotype, Y-chromosome microdeletion and CFTR (the cystic fibrosis gene).
- Sometimes a **scrotal ultrasound**.

Treatment options

Obstructive azoospermia

Surgical repair, such as vasectomy reversal, or sperm retrieval (PESA, MESA or TESA) with the sperm then used in ICSI.

Non-obstructive azoospermia

In some men, hormone treatment. Surgical sperm retrieval, such as micro-TESE, with any sperm found used in ICSI.

Donor sperm

Donor sperm is another route to parenthood. Many couples consider it alongside, or after, other options.

Talk your options through with a urologist or andrologist, who can explain what fits your test results.

 **DISCUSS THIS ON THE FORUM** From Causes of male infertility · [n] members discussing

SUBJECT / STARTED BY	REPLIES / VIEWS	LAST POST
 Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoospermia. Where do we start? Started by dan_r	[n] Replies [n] Views	Just diagnosed with non-obstructive azoo... by jo_partner · 2h ago
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 Karyotype normal, still waiting on Y-microdeletion results Started by sam_k	[n] Replies [n] Views	Karyotype normal, still waiting on Y-micro... by mark_t · Yesterday

You are not alone. Men who have had this diagnosis answer questions here every day.

View the board

+ Ask the community: start a topic

Sources

- [Source 1, e.g. NHS / NICE / WHO guidance]
- [Source 2, e.g. clinical guideline on male infertility]
- [Source 3, e.g. peer-reviewed review article]

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 Yes

No



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